

Standard Operating Procedure (SOP)

Banana Receiving, Handling, and Credit Process

1. Purpose

To ensure bananas are received, handled, and evaluated correctly upon delivery to maintain quality standards, food safety, and to protect the store's ability to request credit for damaged, chilled, or out-of-stage bananas.

2. Scope

This SOP applies to **all banana deliveries**, including pale and ripe bananas, received by the Produce Department.

3. Responsibilities

- **Produce Manager / Receiver**
 - Ensure proper inspection at delivery
 - Verify temperature, ripeness stage, and condition
 - Document and report issues within required timelines
- **Produce Associates**
 - Assist with inspections and handling
 - Notify Produce Manager immediately of any concerns

4. ORDERING PROCEDURES

4.1 Forecasting & Order Timing

- Review **previous 4–6 weeks sales data** to determine average daily movement.
- Consider the following demand factors:
 - Weekly ad promotions
 - Seasonal increases (e.g., school year, holidays, summer traffic)
 - Weather impacts (warm weather → higher fruit sales)
 - Local events influencing traffic

4.2 Two Color Program

Order a balanced mix of ripeness levels to ensure continuous in-stock:

- **75–85%** Stage 2–3 (green to light green)
- **15–25%** Stage 4 (break-ready / yellow with green tips)
- **Refer to Banana Color Chart**

Goal: Ensure customers always find bananas at multiple ripeness stages.

4.3 Quantities

- Maintain **2–3 days of product** in rotation—no more.
- Order smaller, more frequent shipments instead of large loads to avoid ripening issues.

5. Banana Receiving Procedures

5.1 Pallet & Packaging Inspection

Upon arrival:

- Verify bananas are **properly wrapped on the pallet**
- Look for visible damage to cases or fruit
- Do **not** break down pallets until inspection is complete



Retail Handling

- **On Arrival:**
 - Remove blankets or plastic shrouds immediately
 - Remove box lids, pull back plastic and remove extra plastic sheets
 - Place box bottom within lid
 - Segregate boxes according to ripeness
 - Cross stack boxes
 - Maximum of 4 – 5 layers
 - Angle boxes



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5.2 Pulp Temperature Check

1. Use a **calibrated thermometer**
2. Select a banana from the **middle of a case**
3. Insert the thermometer probe **into the fruit pulp**, not all the way through
4. Record the **pulp temperature** (not surface temperature)

Important Notes:

- External temperatures are often lower due to refrigerated trucks
- Always rely on **pulp temperature**

Acceptable Pulp Temperature Range:

✓ 54°F – 65°F

If Pulp Temperature is Below 54°F:

- Take pulp temperatures from **all cases**
- It is rare that all cases will be below temperature
- Document findings with photos

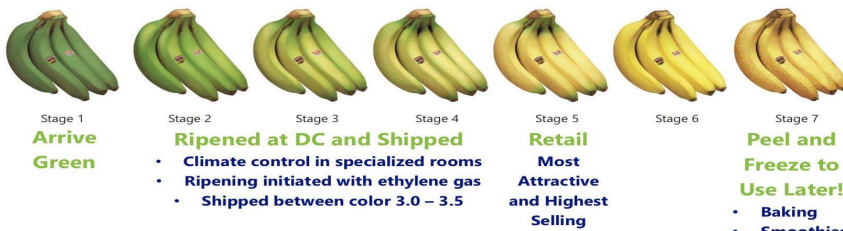
6. Ripeness Stage Verification

Item Codes & Expected Stages

- **494252 – Pale Bananas**
 - Shipped at **Stage 2 or 3**
- **474957 – Ripe Bananas**
 - Shipped at **Stage 3 or 4**



Banana Color Stages



7. Banana Care Guidelines

- Handle cases carefully to prevent bruising
- Avoid exposing bananas to temperatures below 54°F
- Store and ripen bananas according to company ripening standards (see 5.1)
- Rotate stock using **FIFO (First In, First Out)**



Retail Backroom Temperatures

- **Ideal Ambient Storage Temperature**
 - 56 - 60°F
- **Pulp Temperatures**
 - < 56°F: Chill damage
 - 56 - 60°F: ½ color stage progression per day
 - 60 - 65°F: 1 color stage progression per day
 - > 65°F: Premature sugar spotting, soft pulps, rapid progression, reduced shelf life



In Range



Out of Range

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8. Retail Handling



Retail Handling

- **Display:**
 - Take boxes to display on a cart
 - Have a well padded display, avoid abrasive surfaces
 - Carefully place bananas by the crown
 - Display no more than 2 layers high
 - Maintain a clean and stocked display
 - Remove unattractive/over ripe fruit
 - Well stocked displays will increase sales
 - Remove empty boxes



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9. Credit Procedures

8.1 Time Requirements

- Issues must be identified **upon arrival or within 2 hours** of delivery
- **Credit must be requested within 24 hours** of delivery

9.2 Required Inspection Steps for Credit

If issues are found:

1. Verify pallet wrap condition
2. Take pulp temperature from a random case
3. If below 54°F, take temperatures from **all cases**
4. Perform a **visual inspection** for:
 - Incorrect ripeness stage
 - Physical damage
5. Take **clear photos** of all issues

9.3 Photo Documentation Requirements

Photos must include:

- Out-of-stage bananas
- Physically damaged cases
- Low-temperature bananas with:
 - Thermometer **inserted into the fruit**
 - Temperature clearly visible
- Whenever possible, photos should show bananas **still on the pallet upon arrival**

10. Credit Eligibility Guidelines

10.1 Chilled Bananas

- Pulp temperature **below 54°F**
- Will be **credited and picked up**
- Photo evidence of thermometer placement is required

10.2 Out-of-Stage Bananas

- **Stage 7 bananas** will be credited and picked up with proper photos
- Ideally documented while still on the pallet

10.3 Physically Damaged Bananas

- Damaged cases will be credited and picked up
- Photo documentation required (preferably on pallet)

10.4 Case-by-Case Evaluation

The following will be reviewed individually for credit:

- **494252 (Pale Bananas)** received at **Stage 4 or higher**
- **474957 (Ripe Bananas)** received at **Stage 5 or higher**

11. Compliance

Failure to follow this SOP may result in:

- Loss of credit eligibility
- Reduced product quality
- Increased shrink

Produce Managers are responsible for ensuring all team members understand and follow this SOP.

12. Common issue with Bananas

PREMATURE SUGAR SPOTTING—ARE MY BANANAS SICK!?

What is premature sugar spotting?

Premature sugar spotting is defined as bananas that have brown sugar spots while the peel is still partly green.

What causes premature sugar spotting?

Premature sugar spotting can occur when bananas that are too green are exposed to air temperatures above 65°F with relative humidity levels below 85%, right after the bananas were in cooler air temperatures (56°-60°F).

When bananas ripen, the chlorophyll in the peel breaks down to change the fruit color from green to yellow. Sugar spots indicate how much starch in the pulp has converted to sugar. Essentially, when premature sugar spotting occurs, the peel of the banana and the pulp of the banana are ripening at different rates.

How can I prevent it!?

Warehouse: Ship bananas at a minimum of a color stage 3. This allows the bananas to have enough color on the shoulders to encourage normal ripening. Avoid short cycling the fruit with high gassing temperatures to push color.

Retail: Keep backroom temperatures between 56°-65°F. Extremely warm backroom temperatures tend to be the main culprit in cases of premature sugar spotting. Also remember to remove lids, pull out any excess plastic sheets, pull back the plastic bag, and cross-stack banana boxes upon arrival. This allows heat to escape from the boxes, which will help extend the shelf-life of the bananas.



Banana Receiving & Handling Training Checklist

Department: Produce
Employee Name: _____
Trainer: _____
Store #: _____
Date: _____

1. Receiving & Pallet Inspection

- ☒ Employee can:
 - ☐ Verify bananas are **properly wrapped on the pallet**
 - ☐ Identify visible **case or fruit damage**
 - ☐ Understand **not to break down pallets** before inspection
 - ☐ Know to report issues **immediately upon arrival**

2. Pulp Temperature Procedure

- ☒ Employee can correctly:
 - ☐ Use a **calibrated thermometer**
 - ☐ Select a banana from the **middle of the case**
 - ☐ Insert thermometer **into the fruit pulp (not through it)**
 - ☐ Explain the difference between **pulp temperature vs. surface temperature**
 - ☐ State the **acceptable pulp temperature range: 54°F–65°F**

3. Low Temperature Protocol

- ☒ Employee understands:
 - ☐ If one banana is **below 54°F**, all cases must be checked
 - ☐ Chilled bananas (**below 54°F**) qualify for **credit and pickup**
 - ☐ Proper documentation is required for credit eligibility

4. Ripeness Stage Identification

- ☒ Employee can identify and verify:
 - ☐ Banana ripeness stages visually
 - ☐ **494252 – Pale Bananas** ship at **Stage 2–3**
 - ☐ **474957 – Ripe Bananas** ship at **Stage 3–4**
 - ☐ The importance of matching **ordered code to received stage**

5. Out-of-Stage Guidelines

- ☒ Employee understands:
 - ☐ **Stage 7 bananas** qualify for credit with photos
 - ☐ Pale bananas received at **Stage 4+** are case-by-case
 - ☐ Ripe bananas received at **Stage 5+** are case-by-case

6. Photo Documentation Standards

- ☒ Employee can properly document issues by:
 - ☐ Taking photos of **out-of-stage bananas**
 - ☐ Photographing **physically damaged cases**
 - ☐ Taking temperature photos showing:
 - Thermometer **inserted into fruit**
 - Temperature clearly visible
 - ☐ Capturing photos **while product is still on the pallet**, when possible

7. Credit Request Timeline

- ☒ Employee knows:
 - ☐ Issues must be identified **upon arrival or within 2 hours**
 - ☐ Credit must be requested **within 24 hours of delivery**
 - ☐ Late or incomplete documentation may result in **denied credit**

8. Banana Handling & Care

- ☒ Employee demonstrates proper handling by:
 - ☐ Avoiding exposure to temperatures **below 54°F**
 - ☐ Handling cases carefully to **prevent bruising**
 - ☐ Using **FIFO (First In, First Out)** rotation
 - ☐ Following store banana care and ripening standards

9. Final Verification

- ☐ Employee understands when to **escalate issues to Produce Manager**
- ☐ Employee can independently complete banana receiving steps
- ☐ Employee has asked questions and received clarification

Trainer Sign-Off

I confirm this employee has been trained and understands proper banana receiving, handling, and credit procedures.

Trainer Signature: _____ **Date:** _____

Employee Signature: _____ **Date:** _____